Western commentary, even as other commentators urge a return to traditional engagement as practiced until Donald Trump's presidency.[24] Regardless of what approach they advocate, most observers agree that rather than converging, Chinese values are increasingly diverging from those of the West, and that the two systems appear more incompatible than many believed just a decade ago.

China seems to be on a confrontational course with its neighbors and other leading powers, primarily the United States. Often bristling at what it considers condescending attitudes in Washington, Tokyo, and other capitals, and resentful of attempts to force it to play by global rules not of its own design, Beijing is more willing to probe and push the limits of antagonistic behavior, combining military intimidation with diplomatic browbeating and economic blackmail. Given the continued dependence of countries around the world on Chinese-produced goods and access to China's tantalizing market, Beijing has found few capitals willing to stand up to its provocative behavior. Though some writers, mimicking the hyperbolic anti-Japan warnings of the 1980s, darkly intimate of a coming war that can only be avoided by American accommodation of China, a period of intensified competition and antagonistic relations between Beijing and Washington seems almost assured.[25]

The New China Rules: Enforcing Global Compliance

After a long period of biding its time, Beijing has come up with its own way to ensure that its interests are not merely respected but enforced. These are the "new China rules." In addition to outright pressure campaigns against global corporations and national governments, the rules include endemic, aggressive theft of intellectual property (IP) from around the world; pervasive espionage against its so-called international partners; widespread influence campaigns targeting media, politicians, think tanks, and educational institutions; and an unceasing military buildup and extension of Chinese military presence in strategic